ART

REFLECTION AND RESISTANCE

Artist Vibha Galhotra's new show explores the overlapping issues of climate change, political breakdown and rapid urbanisation







SONIC SILENCE (From left clockwise) 'Fractured', metal ghungroos sewn on fabric, board and metal; 'The Weight' metal ghungroos, fabric and stainless steel; 'Untitled', Testimonies from the displaced and found rubble

Delhi-based artist Vibha Galhotra's solo exhibition of new works, *Solastalgia: The Weight in the Air*, draws from philosopher Glenn Albrecht's term used to express the distress caused by environmental change. The sculptures, installation and mixed media on view explore the overlapping crises of climate catastrophe, political breakdown, spiritual confusion and rapid urbanisation.

Central to the show are four large-scale works made from patinated ghunghroos—small metallic bells used by classical Indian dancers. In Galhotra's hands, these bells are stripped of their sound and reassembled into tapestry-like surfaces. 'I Don't Know', 'Temper', 'Fire in the Sky' and 'Fractured', each evoke different facets of collapse and transformation. As the artist notes, "What initially drew me to ghunghroos was their sonic quality, but in my work, they are muted. That silence becomes symbolic—a way to bring attention to stories often ignored or unheard."

SOLASTALGIA: THE WEIGHT IN THE AIR, artist Vibha Galhotra's solo exhibition, is on at Nature Morte Mumbai, Apr. 24-May 31

Among the most powerful pieces in the exhibition is 'Pieces of Memory', an installation built from rubble collected across Indian cities. This concrete detritus is rearranged into a contemplative monument, asking viewers to reckon with the environmental and emotional costs of progress.

In 'Vanishing of Flags' and 'Rise of Roots', Galhotra juxtaposes fragile architectural outlines with creeping organic forms, suggesting the eventual triumph of the natural world over human ambition. "There's grief, yes," she says, "but also the possibility that something new might rise from the ruins." Elsewhere, in a series titled 'New Age Noise', Galhotra plays with perception: images of everyday violence, etched onto glass, only become visible when illuminated by a phone flashlight—underscoring the omnipresent yet often invisible brutality of modern life.

Galhotra, trained at Kala Bhavan, Santiniketan, has long been interested in the intersections of art, activism and environmental consciousness. Her works are part of major collections including the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art, the Gates Foundation and the Singapore Art Museum.

The exhibition is accompanied by programming developed in collaboration with Carpe Arte and OpenCall India—two women-led initiatives fostering conversation and access within India's contemporary art scene. Talks, workshops and public events will amplify the show's themes. In *Solastalgia*, Galhotra does not pretend to offer solutions. Her work confronts us with uncomfortable truths—about the systems we are complicit in, the damage we have normalised and the future we fear. And yet, amid the noise and the rubble, it also allows space for reflection, and perhaps a glimmer of redemption. ■

–Nikhil Sardana